



BUDAPEST HUNGARY

On Budapest's Paprika Trail

One of Europe's great capitals, Budapest combines the drama of its Danube-spanning location with the mystique of a city that has witnessed great events in history. Ottoman conquerors, Habsburg monarchs, and Communist planners have all left their mark, but it is in Budapest's markets, coffeehouses, and restaurants that you will find the ebb and flow of Hungarian life.



The name Budapest literally links a city of two halves: tranquil, hilly Buda on the west bank of the Danube, and bustling

Pest, with its shops, cafés, and museums, on the eastern bank. The castle district on Buda Hill recalls the glory days of Hungary's medieval monarchs and their Habsburg successors, while over the river in Pest, boulevards heavy with 19th-century buildings convey a palpable sense of national pride. Elsewhere, downtown facades are studded with decorative motifs, constituting a three-dimensional pattern book of early Hungarian (Magyar) folk art. Modern buildings such as the wonderful Ludwig Museum of Modern Art on the banks of the Danube River reveal that Budapest is a restlessly contemporary city too.

Hungarians take their food very seriously. Bakery counters groan under the weight of speckled loaves and rolls, café windows contain displays of delicate pastries and cakes, and chalkboards outside restaurants deliver the rich promise of roast breast of duck or fried liver of goose. However, no dish sums up Hungarian culinary culture more than goulash, the ubiquitous paprika-flavored stew whose origins are as old as the Hungarian nation.

For many, the word "goulash" is a catch-all term, but in Hungary itself the word *gulyás* usually refers to a rather thin stew that is served as a soup; the full-blooded stew that most non-Hungarians would consider to be goulash goes by the name of *pörkölt*. This is most often made with chunks of veal (*borjúpörkölt*), although there are many variations – *pörkölt* featuring huge, scaly chunks of freshwater fish is a favorite in the south. There is also a silkier version of goulash known as *paprikás*, thickened with lots of cream. All of these dishes originated in the simple stews prepared by Hungarian cattle-drovers over campfires, and you'll still see them served in traditional metal dishes, or *bogrács*, with a huge ladle protruding from the rim.

In Budapest you'll find goulash on menus everywhere, from bus station buffets to high-class restaurants. The one essential ingredient is paprika, the frequently fiery spice grown on a huge scale throughout southern Hungary. Strings of dried paprikas are a colorful feature of Budapest's markets, where they are labeled according to their heat and flavor – there are eight grades, ranging from the sweet and mild *különleges* to the maroon-colored, tongue-blisteringly hot *erős*.

A Day in Budapest

Bisected by the mighty Danube, Budapest has been destroyed and rebuilt over the centuries, giving it an eclectic appearance and elegant feel. The banks of the river have UNESCO World Heritage status, justifying the city's name, the "Pearl of the Danube."

MORNING Start off by visiting **Buda**, a historical quarter of 18th-century mansions and cobbled squares. The parapets of the **Fishermen's Bastion** provide sumptuous views across the Danube River.

AFTERNOON Cross the river to **Pest** and its animated main shopping street, **Váci utca**, pausing for coffee and cake in one of the many fine café-pâtisseries. Afterward, take a trip on the 100-year-old M1 metro line to leafy **Városliget Park**, where both a zoo and a reconstructed Transylvanian castle await. If you have time for a gallery, the **Museum of Applied Arts** is the ideal introduction to Hungarian visual style.

EVENING Promenade along Pest's Danube shore and admire the illuminated bridges before heading for **Ráday utca**, an up-and-coming area of cafés and restaurants.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Flights arrive at **Ferihegy Airport**; buses travel the 10 miles (16 km) to the downtown.

WHERE TO STAY

Anna (inexpensive) is a small, homey B&B in a central Pest location. www.annahotel.hu
Ibis Centrum (moderate) is in a lively part of Pest. www.ibis-centrum.hu

Danubius Hotel Gellért (expensive) combines Art Nouveau elegance with proximity to the world-famous Gellért thermal baths complex. www.danubiushotels.com/gellert

TOURIST INFORMATION

Sütő u. 2, Deák tér; www.budapestinfo.hu

